

5.4 Gravitational fields

This section provides knowledge and understanding of Newton's law of gravitation, planetary motion and gravitational potential and energy.

Newton's law of gravitation can be used to predict the motion of orbiting satellites, planets and even why some objects in our Solar system have very little atmosphere with the opportunity to analyse evidence and look at causal relationships (HSW1, 2, 5, 7).

Geostationary satellites have done much to improve telecommunications around the world. They are expensive; governments and industry have to make difficult decisions when building new ones. Learners have the opportunity to discuss the societal benefits of satellites and the risks they pose when accidents do occur (HSW9, 10).